TANGKHUL KINSHIP TERMINOLOGY, CONSANGUINITY, AND LINEAGE STRUC

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ABSTRACT:

Kinship terminologies embody the social structural logic and reciprocal obligations of human societies. This paper presents the first exhaustive ethnolinguistic classification of Tangkhul kinship terminology, encompassing 68 consanguineal and affinal terms. We demonstrate that Tangkhul exhibits a bifurcate merging system of the Omaha subtype, reflecting strict patrilineal clan organization (Shang) and asymmetrical cross-cousin marriage rules.

Keywords: Kinship, Omaha Type, Shang, Consanguinity, Ethnolinguistics, Thirumalai

1. BIFURCATE MERGING & PATRILINEAL ALIGNMENT

In Tangkhul, the father’s brother is addressed by the same root as father (Ava-kakhano for father’s younger brother, Ava-kakhara for father’s elder brother), whereas the mother’s brother is distinguished as Mawa/Kuku. Similarly, parallel cousins are equated with biological siblings (Uningnao), whereas cross-cousins fall into distinct terminological classes linked to marriageability.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** Ava : father**

Analysis: Primary consanguineal male ancestor.

*** Ava-kakhano : father’s younger brother**

Analysis: Bifurcate merging parallel uncle.

*** Mawa / Kuku : mother’s brother (maternal uncle)**

Analysis: Affinal alliance partner.

2. SIBLING TERMINOLOGY & SENIORITY DISTINCTIONS

Seniority relative to the speaker is strictly encoded in sibling terms. Elder brother is achon/ayei, younger brother is atat/akhanao, elder sister is va-kakhara, and younger sister is va-kakhano. The collective compound uningnao encompasses all sibling kin within the Shang lineage.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** ayei : elder brother**

Analysis: Senior male sibling.

*** akhanao : younger sibling (male or female)**

Analysis: Junior sibling term.

*** uningnao : lineage siblings / clan brethren**

Analysis: Collective kinship noun.

3. AFFINAL TERMINOLOGIES & ASYMMETRICAL ALLIANCES

Affinal terms reflect mother’s brother’s daughter (MBD) preferential alliance. The wife’s clan is honored as Mayang-shang (life-giving in-laws), commanding ceremonial gifts of meat and woven shawls at all lifecycle rituals.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** Mayang-shang : wife-giving affinal clan lineage**

Analysis: Ceremonial in-law alliance.

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